opposition from the All India Student Federation (AISF) as well as other Muslim student groups, but through their lobbying the AIMSF was able to get wider support. While the initial objective of the federation was to lobby for the rights of Muslim minorities, it soon became involved in the Pakistan cause, actively supporting the All India Muslim League (AIML) (Altbach 1970). While other regional student groups had emerged across India, the Punjab Muslim Students Federation (PMSF) was further instrumental in supporting the Pakistan movement. PMSF support was considered to be one of the main factors that led to the victory of the AIML in the 1946 elections in Punjab; AIML defeated the once dominant Unionist party (Mirza 1991).

The role of student unions in supporting mainstream political parties had already been defined in the years before partition. 'Students who played an important part in the League's election campaign, had in particular been trained to appeal to the electorate along religious lines' (Talbot 1980, p. 77). These included 'Aligarh students' who came to the Punjab to support the AIML. The extent of this support can be gauged from the fact that 'during the peak of student activity, the 1945 Christmas vacation, there were 1550 members of the Punjab Muslim Students' Federation and 250 Aligarh students working on the League's behalf' (Talbot 1980, p. 78). The 1946 victory was important in furthering the agenda of the AIML, and strengthening the Pakistan cause.

After independence, the AIMSF like the AIML fell victim to internal politics that resulted in these organizations breaking apart into factions, and the emergence of other student political groups. However, the links between student groups and political parties outside the university continued to develop where ideological battles among national or provincial players were also reflected on university campuses through rivalries and strategic coalitions. Nelson (2011) highlights how after independence the emergence of the Democratic Students Federation (DSF) linked to the Communist Party of Pakistan was perceived to be a threat by the ruling Pakistan Muslim League which created a new 'state sponsored student union' the National Students Federation (NSF) to counter this threat. However, by the early 1950s the DSF members had overtaken the NSF, making it another leftist party. Bajwa in her discussion of the DSF highlights its popularity in Karachi when it swept 'most of the college union elections in Karachi and initiated the Inter-Collegiate Body (ICB) to unify the student unions under one banner' (Bajwa 2015, p. 12). The extent of the threat of the DSF was evident in the eventual ban in 1954 of the Communist Party of Pakistan and the DSF (Nelson 2011). The political debates on campus were increasingly